Answering 8-Mark Questions

Exam code: 9BS0

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How do I answer an Edexcel A level Business 8-mark question?

- These questions appear in Paper 3 only
- Two marks are available for knowledge, two for application, two for analysis and two for evaluation.

Suggested structure

- Key business skills are highlighted:

Knowledge Application Analysis Evaluation

Step 1
• Start off with a **definition of the key term** in the question stem   ○ This will secure some Level 1 knowledge marks and can help you focus your response
Flexible working is any working arrangement which allows the amount, timing or location of work to be varied for the mutual benefit of the individual and the business. Definition provides strong knowledge
Step 2

• In the next paragraph, you should start your analysis by **making a strong point**
  ○ Support it with some relevant **context** from the stimulus material
  ▪ Quoting some data, including a calculation, or remarking on a key business feature or trend are good ways to do this
  ○ Develop a chain of reasoning that develops the point logically. The X→Y→Z approach is a good way to build a coherent chain:

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effectively. For example:

- E.g. X_1 and X_2 lead to Y, which results in Z ***or*** X leads to Y_1 and/or Y_2, which results in Z ***or*** X leads to Y, which results in Z_1 and/or Z_2

Using part-time contracts means that The Wonky Table can organise staffing to meet operational needs. Restaurant bookings are often higher at weekends so part-time restaurant and kitchen staff hours could be concentrated at these times. The Wonky Table could avoid staff being underutilised during less busy times of the week and capable of delivering good customer service with ample staff at busier times.

Stating correct points shows knowledge

Some analysis, though not fully developed

Step 3

- In the next paragraph, you need to show balance by **providing a counterpoint**
  - Make a logical, relevant counterpoint. Make sure that it is relevant to the question
  - A further chain of XYZ reasoning, with context, is also required
    - This is particularly important in 8–mark questions, as a conclusion or recommendation is not required
    - Evaluation marks are, instead, awarded for effective balance

Secondly, flexible working arrangements such as job rotation can be a useful way for The Wonky Table to increase the range of skills of its staff. Kitchen staff may switch between the preparation of different dishes, whilst front-of-house staff may move between making bookings and serving diners. Equipping staff with a range of skills could improve flexibility, allowing staff to cover absent colleagues and provide the same level of customer service. However, not all tasks can be completed by non-specialists. Roles such as Head Chef require skill, experience and significant training to prepare high-quality dishes. In these cases flexible working is unlikely to make a difference and The Wonky Table would need to have effective contingency plans in place to cover absence periods of key staff.

Correct point

Examples provide further knowledge

Another strong XYZ chain of analysis

Clear links to the context

Balance = both sides considered

Step 4

- Repeat steps two and three with a further point and counterpoint

staff may switch between the preparation of different dishes, whilst front-of-house staff may move between making bookings and serving diners. Equipping staff with a range of skills could improve flexibility, allowing staff to cover absent colleagues and provide the same level of customer service.

However, not all tasks can be completed by non-specialists. Roles such as Head Chef require skill, experience and significant training to prepare high-quality dishes. In these cases flexible working is unlikely to make a difference and The Wonky Table would need to have effective contingency plans in place to cover absence periods of key staff.

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